Jewel

By Joan MacLeod

RADIO: **(Pg 72)** To Connie Brown: Happy Valentine's. Wish I could be there with love from Stanley . . . **(Pg 73)** To Sally Harper: Happy Valentines. You are my one and only, love Frank . . . **(Pg 71-72)** and that's it for Message Time tonight. Happy Valentine's. And snuggle up to the one you love because it's a chilly thirty-three below in Fort St. John tonight.

MARJORIE: You hear that, Harry? Cozy up. *(Marjorie turns off the radio and as she gazes at her wedding ring, she remembers)* **(Pg 69)** Valentine's 1979. . . His face: high cheekbones, lashes like a woman's, black hair sticking out in a million directions. And at six minutes to midnight, he asked you . . . "Marry me, Marjorie." There's this land he's wanting to buy and no money for cattle yet, but the oil patch is right around the corner. He's got his welder's papers. The money will flow. Maybe five winters of working out then fulltime farming or ranching. He talks about buying a milk cow and you nearly pass out with the romance of it. Valentine's . .

(Pg 79) [But] today I was at the Co-op in town, buying groceries. And this kid who's working there yells from across the parking lot, "Hey Mitchell! What's got four legs, is three hundred feet tall and goes down on Newfoundland?" And this kid Mitchell looks real embarrassed because he knows who I am. I mean I am one hell of a famous widow, Harry. We're talking *Time* magazine. And this kid yells again, "What's a thousand feet tall, has four legs and goes down on Newfoundland?" This idiot, he yells it out *(beat)* "The *Ocean Ranger!"*

INTRODUCTION

*In 1982, the world's largest mobile offshore rig, the **Ocean Ranger**, was drilling for oil off the Newfoundland coast. Since its 1976 launch, the big rig had weathered over 50 storms; designed for 115 mph winds and 110-foot waves, and everyone thought it could handle the storm that was brewing too. But at 1:00 a.m. on February 15, 1982, the crew sent a desperate mayday call. Nearby vessels arrived only an hour later to find rescue impossible on the freezing, tall waves. Of the Ocean Ranger's 84 crewmembers, only 22 bodies were ever recovered. Autopsies confirmed they died from hypothermia, and the 62 missing were presumed to have met a similar fate. They were never recovered. Marjorie Clifford was widowed that day; this is her story. Jewel by Joan MacLeod*

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MARJORIE: **(Pg 80-83)** You know I always thought it was a ridiculous name -- the *Ocean Ranger. W*hen you first got the job, I panicked because I didn't know how to imagine you there. Usually, you were just up around Nelson and I knew I could jump in the truck and find you. But Newfoundland! Four thousand miles away. Right from the start it felt wrong. I mean we're supposed to be farmers and there you are out on this floating thing in the middle of the Atlantic Ocean. *(beat)*

When I got the call that you'd gone down, all I could think was that you were drifting, that you might get caught up in kelp or some current -- that you'd never arrive on something solid again. And I thought about that Harry, non-stop. Thought about that for fourteen months without a break.

I was living with my folks, and my mother signs me up for some god-awful thing called a grieving workshop. All this group stuff makes me mental. I mean this is a very private business if you ask me. Everyone wanting me to come to terms with this. And all I'm really wanting is for everyone just to leave me alone. Some church ran this thing and they're tossing scripture around like a volleyball. I mean as if that's going to fill my bed or help me make payments.

Okay, we got our money since then. After two years of drawn-out bullshit with lawyers and every time you open the paper, more stuff about the *Ocean Ranger. [But]* What I want, through the whole inquiry, is to narrow it down to one man. Leave me one man, up there on the top floor, behind some marble top desk. I want him to say "Yup, it was my fault -- the design flaws, the lack of survival suits, my fault about the evacuation procedure and that the lifeboats would've gone down in a lake. I screwed up. Big time."

I don't want to cause this man any harm. But I would like to place him aboard a drilling platform, after midnight in February, over a hundred miles from the coast of Newfoundland. An alarm calls this man from sleep and onto a deck that is pitch black and tipped over fifteen degrees and all covered in ice. The wind is screaming. Salt water and

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snow pelt his face. Nobody knows what to do. He is being lowered in a life raft with twenty other men, into a sea of fifty-foot waves. Then I would reach down and lift that man up from this terrible place just like the hand of God come to save him. Remove him from all that terror and certain death. I'd place him somewhere warm and dry. Take his shivering hand inside my own and turn his hand over and over and over. Until he sees it. ***His hand*** is the hand of God, and he could have gathered them all up. Saved eighty-four men from the North Atlantic. He chose not to. My sadness -- my husband's death -- it was hand-made by someone.

(Pg 84-85) Well, old friend. *(MARJORIE looks at her ring)* You don't have a heart and you don't have a memory anymore. I suppose that part's the truth. But I do. This summer . . . I'd just moved back here, and everyone was so worried that I'd go crazy again. And sure enough, that's when I started having these little night-time chats of ours. *(long beat as she tries to reign in her emotion, then)* *Damn* you, Harry! Dying and leaving me is about the most gutless thing anyone could ever do. *(she breathes deeply and composes herself)* That's called the Angry Phase, Harry. I think I'm starting to come out of it though. *(beat)*

I'll tell you a story. There is a guy teaching school here. He's a very nice man. Sort of shy. Or maybe it's lack of character. No. There's something quite good there. **(Pg 86)** His name is Gordon, Harry. His place is all cedar and the smell of wood makes me crazy. *(She breathes in deeply through her nose, remembering)*

That first winter with you in the cabin . . . We were just married, and I don't care a damn that there's no power or water and nearly no windows. That making coffee means half a day's work. But then I begin to notice everything; nothing is smooth, it's dark all the time, my clothes are alive with sawdust and the walls are alive with sap. So it starts. **(Pg 89)** Used to be I hated the night coming but it's alright now. I mean it's not out-and-out terror anymore. Not all the time at least. *(She notices the time and shakes off the memory)*

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(Pg 87) Gordon asked me to stay overnight. But I didn't. I didn't stay overnight, but I did go to bed with him. I'm just telling you, not asking permission. Being held by living arms, brings home what a body must be like lifeless. How it is still ***your*** body that I know better than my own. All the women wanted the bodies found, all the families of the victims. I never thought it'd be like that. You'd think lost would be better than dead. A strand of hope, invisible thin. But it makes you crazy, never knowing a hundred percent. It was way harder in the long run.

(Pg 89-90) Just a few more things, Harry. Then I'm going to bed. They got me going to another widows' group twice a month. There's this one woman, around your mum's age. And she says that widowhood, it's like checking into a motel for one night. One night that lasts the rest of your life. Then this lady says that nothing feels like home anymore. It's like we're all just waiting to get to another place. And I thought -- right, Not that I think I'm going to another place. It's just that it feels like that . . . the waiting. **(Pg 91)** Sometimes I do feel like I'm just visiting here, not really able to get involved in anything. And very, very scared. But I'll tell you something. I am beginning to feel again . . . I'm not just waiting, not anymore. Not held down by that sadness. I mean I know it's part of me, but it can't run the show forever. *(MARJORIE looks at her ring)* What do you think of that? My perfect jewel. *(She is again swept into a memory)*

(Pg 92-93) Valentine's 1982. You are about to slam, face first, into such a storm. But not yet. Maybe it's still quiet out there, just for a moment. I hope so. It's just before noon. I come in the kitchen, the radio's on. And there it is. First one out of the gate, a Valentine's message, short and sweet and probably sent the day before but meant to be mine now. "To Marjorie Clifford . . . " I carry it around inside, hold onto it all day. It sends me to bed warm. Loud and clear. You love me. You got through.

Then late that night another message, hand delivered by an embarrassed *police officer.* The rig has been evacuated. Evacuated. What does it mean? Bombed out villages,

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buildings. Living in an air raid shelter. Living. He has left the rig and is in a lifeboat. There is a bad storm, a fifty-foot sea. That's when I know. Anything that big and made out of water is a deadly thing. But don't think it or it will be true and my fault. My legs are weak. I grab hold of the counter and the kitchen floor moves like a raft underneath me. And there you are, clear as ice for a single moment. In a little boat, wearing that awful parka from Sears. The *police officer* catches me down on my knees on the cold linoleum. He shakes his head. This is very hard for him, trying to tell me that my husband is dead. But he doesn't tell me that. He says the rig has gone down and two of the lifeboats, but the third boat is still out there. That means you. ***I know it.*** But then this cop tells me not to have much hope. I should've listened to him. It would've made the next few days a lot easier. All that waiting and glued to the radio. **(Pg 94)** Then the names of the dead are read over the radio. [Nicholas Baldwin, Kenneth Blackmore, Thomas Blevins,*] Harry Clifford. Confirmed.

It's nearly midnight, Harry. Valentine's is coming to a close. Remember how I told you that first message sent me to bed warm? It's still there. A little bit. *(MARJORIE removes her ring.)* But wearing this forever. I don't think it's such a great idea anymore. **(Pg 95)** It always felt so mean that **it** had to be Valentine's Day, that it was the last day you were alive. But I'm not so sure anymore. This is what I'm sure of. You loved me. You got through.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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* Names added from the *names of the men lost on the Ocean Ranger found at* *http://dorothystewart.net/2012/02/14/ocean-ranger-30/*

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